# Youssef Benzarti

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*Citizenship:* Morocco, Tunisia, United States. October 2026
*Research and teaching fields:* Public finance.

## Academic Appointments

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|---|---|
| University of California, Santa Barbara — *Associate Professor of Economics* | July 2022 – present |
| Public Finance Lab, UCSB — *Director* | July 2024 – present |
| National Bureau of Economic Research — *Research Associate* | September 2026 – present |
| National Bureau of Economic Research — *Faculty Research Fellow* | May 2017 – September 2026 |
| University of California, Santa Barbara — *Assistant Professor of Economics* | July 2018 – June 2022 |
| University of California, Los Angeles — *Assistant Professor of Economics* | July 2016 – June 2018 |
| California Center for Population Research — *Faculty Affiliate* | July 2016 – June 2018 |

## Editorial Responsibilities

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| *Review of Economics and Statistics* — *Associate Editor* | April 2025 – present |
| *European Economic Review* — *Associate Editor* | Nov. 2022 – Sept. 2025 |

## Visits

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|---|---|
| Brown University — *Department of Economics* | January – May 2020 |
| University of Michigan — *Office of Tax Policy Research* | September 2017 |

## Education

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| **University of California, Berkeley** — PhD in Economics | 2016 |
| Dissertation committee: Emmanuel Saez, Alan Auerbach and Stefano DellaVigna. | |
| **Paris School of Economics** — MA in Economics | 2010 |
| **HEC Paris** — MSc in Management | 2009 |

## Book

*The Tax Mirage*. Under contract, Princeton University Press. A general-reader book on tax incidence: who actually bears American taxes, and why the political debate gets it wrong.

## Publications

1. Benzarti, Youssef and Dorian Carloni. "Who Really Benefits from Consumption Tax Cuts? Evidence from a Large VAT Reform in France." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, February 2019. NBER Working Paper No. 23848.
2. Benzarti, Youssef, Jarkko Harju and Tuomas Matikka. "Does Mandating Social Insurance Affect Entrepreneurial Activity?" *American Economic Review: Insights*, June 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 25651.

3. Benzarti, Youssef. "How Taxing Is Tax Filing? Using Revealed Preferences to Estimate Compliance Costs." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, November 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 23903.
4. Benzarti, Youssef, Dorian Carloni, Jarkko Harju and Tuomas Kosonen. "What Goes Up May Not Come Down: Asymmetric Incidence of Value Added Taxes." *Journal of Political Economy*, December 2020. NBER Working Paper No. 23849.
5. Benzarti, Youssef. "Estimating the Costs of Filing Tax Returns and the Potential Savings from Policies Aimed at Reducing These Costs." *Tax Policy and the Economy*, 2021, Vol. 35. NBER Working Paper No. 27946.
6. Benzarti, Youssef and Alisa Tazhitdinova. "Do Value-Added Taxes Affect International Trade Flows? Evidence From 30 Years of Tax Reforms." *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*, 2021, 13(4), 469–89. NBER Working Paper No. 26195.
7. Benzarti, Youssef and Jarkko Harju. "Using Payroll Tax Variation to Unpack the Black Box of Firm-Level Production." *Journal of the European Economic Association*, 2021, 19(5), 2737–2764. NBER Working Paper No. 26640.
8. Benzarti, Youssef and Jarkko Harju. "Can Payroll Tax Cuts Help Firms During Recessions?" *Journal of Public Economics*, 2021, 200, 104472. NBER Working Paper No. 27485.
9. Benzarti, Youssef. "Playing Hide and Seek: How Lenders Respond to Borrower Protection." *Review of Economics and Statistics*, 2024, 106(2), 384–393. NBER Working Paper No. 26382.
10. Benzarti, Youssef and Luisa Wallossek. "Rising Income Tax Complexity." *National Tax Journal*, 2024, Vol. 77, No. 1. NBER Working Paper No. 31944.
11. Benzarti, Youssef. "Tax Incidence Anomalies." *Annual Review of Economics*, August 2025. NBER Working Paper No. 32819.
12. Benzarti, Youssef, Santiago Garriga and Dario Tortarolo. "Can VAT Cuts and Anti-Profiteering Measures Dampen the Effects of Food Price Inflation?" June 2024. Conditionally accepted at the *American Economic Review*. NBER Working Paper No. 32241.

## Working Papers

13. Benzarti, Youssef, Jarkko Harju, Ella Mattinen, Tuomas Matikka and Alisa Tazhitdinova. "Moral Hazard and Adverse Selection in the Social Insurance Market for Entrepreneurs." July 2026.
14. Jysmä, Sami, Youssef Benzarti and Jarkko Harju. "Policy Thresholds as Growth Barriers: Theory and Evidence from a Payroll Tax Notch." NBER Working Paper No. 35484, July 2026.
15. Huet-Vaughn, Emiliano and Youssef Benzarti. "Modern US Workers' Compensation and Work-Related Injury: No Evidence of Moral Hazard." NBER Working Paper No. 28187, November 2020.

## Expert Testimony

Expert witness in *Federal Trade Commission v. H&R Block* (report and deposition), 2025.

## Honors and Awards

*Journal of the European Economic Association*: Excellence in Refereeing Award 2022
*American Economic Review: Insights*: Excellence in Refereeing Award 2021, 2022

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| Social Sciences and Humanities Research Council of Canada Grant ($50,800), with Alisa Tazhitdinova | 2018 |
| Best Paper, Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics | 2016 |
| California Center for Population Research Junior Faculty Course Release Program | 2016 |
| Outstanding Doctoral Dissertations in Government Finance and Taxation Award, Honorable Mention, National Tax Association | 2016 |
| Department of Economics Graduate Student Award for Public Policy Research, UC Berkeley | 2016 |
| Center for Equitable Growth Fellowship; Doctoral Completion Fellowship | 2015 |
| Russell Sage Foundation Summer Institute in Behavioral Economics | 2014 |
| Robert D. Burch Center for Tax Policy and Public Finance Fellowship | 2014 |
| Graduate Division Summer Research Grant, UC Berkeley | 2011, 2014 |
| Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor, UC Berkeley | 2013 |
| Gateway Fellowship, UC Berkeley International House | 2011 |
| Department Fellowship, UC Berkeley Department of Economics | 2010, 2011 |
| Sandler Fellowship | 2010 |

## Invited Presentations

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| Columbia University; Duke University. | 2027 |
| UC Davis; University of Michigan; SITE (Stanford Institute for Theoretical Economics). | 2026 |
| University of Chicago Harris; University of British Columbia; UC Santa Cruz; EU Tax Observatory Conference (keynote). | 2025 |
| University of Iowa; Madrid Public Economics Workshop (keynote). | 2024 |
| George Washington University; Texas A&M. | 2023 |
| University of Utah; UC Irvine. | 2022 |
| Imperial College London; Santa Clara University; Queen Mary University of London. | 2021 |
| University of Chicago Harris; NYU Law and Economics; University of South Carolina; NBER Tax Policy and the Economy. | 2020 |
| UC Berkeley; ENS Lyon; Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics. | 2019 |
| University of Oregon; National Tax Association; World Bank. | 2018 |
| NBER Summer Institute Public Finance/Labor Studies; Columbia Law School; Cornell; Georgetown; Claremont Graduate School; Cal Poly State University; University of Victoria; University of Warwick; London School of Economics; Institute for Fiscal Studies; University College London; AEA Annual Meetings; Arizona State University; Southern California Conference in Applied Microeconomics; UCSD; UCLA Law School; UCSB. | 2017 |
| UCLA; Princeton; Harvard Kennedy School of Government; University of Toronto; University of Massachusetts Amherst; Mathematica; Paris School of Economics (PSI seminar); National Tax Association; University of Michigan; IIPF; NYU/UCLA Tax Policy Symposium. | 2016 |
| U.S. Department of the Treasury; SITE Psychology and Economics, Stanford; National Tax Association; Canadian Public Economics Group; Aarhus University; Bay Area Labor and Public Finance Conference; UC Berkeley Public Finance and Psychology and Economics Seminars; McMaster University. | 2015 |
| Tax Systems Conference (Michigan and Oxford); Paris 2 (CRED); ENSAE (CREST). | 2014 |
| UC Berkeley Psychology and Economics Non-Lunch Seminar. | 2013 |
| UC Berkeley Public Finance and Labor Economics Lunch Seminar. | 2012 |

## Teaching

**University of California, Santa Barbara.** Using Big Data to Solve Economic and Social Problems; Intermediate Microeconomics; Introduction to Economics; Graduate Public Finance (Taxation); Graduate Behavioral Public Economics; Graduate Research Seminar; Applied Micro Lunch; Public Finance.

**Brown University.** Graduate Public Finance — Social Insurance (Spring 2020).

**University of California, Los Angeles.** Graduate Public Finance (Taxation); Facts About Inequality; Undergraduate Microeconomics; Applied Micro Seminar.

**University of California, Berkeley.** Undergraduate Game Theory.

## Mentoring

**Graduate students** (placement in parentheses). Sarah Robinson (Claremont McKenna College); Wookun Kim (Southern Methodist University); Matt Fitzgerald (Intensity); Dong Ook Eun (Resolution Economics); Luisa Wallossek (University of Oslo).

**PhD defence jury.** Santiago Garriga.

**Undergraduate students** ([*] placed in a PhD programme). Kazuma Wells (MIT); Jen Kades (Duke[*]); Sarah Gharbi (Mannheim[*]); Ziao Ju (Stanford[*]); Marty Chen (University of Maryland[*]).

## Service

**National Bureau of Economic Research.** Co-organizer, Public Economics Fall Meeting, 2026.

**National Tax Association.** Program Committee member, 2021 and 2024.

**International Institute of Public Finance.** Scientific Committee, 2024.

**Department of Economics, UCSB.** Undergraduate Committee; Wilcox Chair Search Committee; Graduate Committee; Academic Senate Representative; Diversity, Equity and Inclusion Committee (chair); Hiring Committee.

**Department of Economics, UCLA.** Graduate Admissions Committee, 2017–2018.

## Referee Service

*American Economic Journal: Applied Economics*; *American Economic Journal: Economic Policy*; *American Economic Review*; *American Economic Review: Insights*; *Econometrica*; *Economic Inquiry*; *Economic Journal*; *Economics Letters*; *International Tax and Public Finance*; *Journal of the European Economic Association*; *Journal of Economic Behavior and Organization*; *Journal of Political Economy*; *Journal of Public Economics*; *Journal of Risk and Insurance*; *National Tax Journal*; *Oxford Economic Papers*; *Quarterly Journal of Economics*; *Review of Economics and Statistics*; *Review of Economic Studies*.

## Other

**Languages.** Arabic (native), English (fluent), French (fluent).

**Affiliations.** American Economic Association; National Tax Association.